

an international border because in Pakistan the thinking is that the LOC is the problem. We don't accept it in Pakistan. Therefore, we have to find a way, a via media, that is acceptable to both sides.

Q. One of the major problems for India is that while Pakistan insists on the centrality of Kashmir, it plays down the centrality of terror and stopping it. How can India negotiate with a gun to our heads? You gave commitments to stop terror that were not upheld. Your territory was used to plan and execute the Mumbai attacks.

A. If you are trying to indicate that the ISI, army or the Government of Pakistan had a role in the Mumbai attacks, I don't agree. It should be taken as a terrorist incident and we should jointly investigate and try to find out who the culprits are and bring them to justice. What must be stopped both by India and Pakistan is each other's governments meddling in the internal affairs of the other.

Q. The Pakistan's Government's reaction to the Mumbai attacks was first cooperation, then prevarication. It resulted in a huge loss of credibility for Pakistan in India. If you were in power, would you have reacted in the same way?

A. That is unfortunate. We shouldn't be flip-flopping. There shouldn't be different opinions being aired by the Government. This happens when opinions are given impulsively without the backing of full intelligence. We should cooperate in all ways to unearth or find out whoever did it. But to pin down and cast aspersions on the ISI is what I object to. Both the R&AW and ISI have been protecting their countries and their own interests in their own ways. Having been president and having seen evidence, I know what your consulates in Kandahar and Jalalabad are doing in Afghanistan. We have to stop all this. Somebody here has to be bold enough to tell the R&AW to stop and somebody in Pakistan has to be bold enough to tell the ISI to stop all this.

Q. You are not for sending those arrested in Pakistan for plotting the Mumbai attacks to India?

A. No, they should not be. Look, would you send Colonel Purohit who killed 61 Pakistanis on the Samjhauta Express for trial in Pakistan? He is a serving officer. Yet our army or the ISI is the rogue. Try to treat Pakistan with sovereign equality. Don't treat us like something small that needs to be pressured, ordered or coerced, and say, do this otherwise we will sort you out. Now this talk of surgical strikes, sir, it does not go well with the army.

Q. What does it mean to you—surgical strikes? Where do you think India will strike?

A. Whenever you strike, there will be a strike back. I am a soldier and if you strike, I won't be worth my salt if I don't

strike back. It annoys the officers and soldiers in Pakistan: how dare they talk of surgical strikes.

Q. Are you saying there will be a full-scale war if India carries out a surgical strike on terror camps?

A. Obviously. We are a sovereign country. You cannot do that. It portends a full-scale war.

Q. Every international terror incident has some kind of Pakistan link. It's been documented by the FBI and Scotland Yard. That's why it gives the suspicion of some state involvement.

A. There is no state involvement but what you mention about Pakistan being linked with terror activities is unfortunate. Yes, indeed there are terrorists and there is extremism in this area. Why has it occurred? From 1979 onwards—30 years, or one-third of a century, it has suffered. First there was a jihad against the Soviets invasion of Afghanistan for 10 years. The Soviets were defeated. Then for the next 12 years, 1989 to 2001, internecine fighting raged between the warlords bent on destroying each other. The 20,000 or 30,000 mujahideen brought in to fight the Soviets, including Osama bin Laden and Ayman al Zawahiri, remained in Afghanistan. Then came 9/11 and the attack on Afghanistan by the coalition forces. Most of the Al Qaeda and Taliban ran away to the safety of Pakistan—to our cities and mountains. We acted against them and from the hundreds they are now down to penny packets. Whose success is this? It is that of the Pakistan armed forces and the ISI.

Q. You ran Pakistan for 10 years and are called a survivor. What went wrong?

A. My popularity went down because of misperceptions, among other things on flushing out terrorists from the Lal Masjid. I still maintain it was an absolutely correct decision. Then there was the lawyers' issue. Whatever I did was legal and constitutional but it was perceived as wrong. During all this political upheaval, elections were held and the PPP and PML(N) won. As a sitting president, I had constitutionally no powers; whatever powers I was wielding were informal. Now here I was, a president who didn't enjoy the confidence of the winning parties. I was going to be a Mr Nobody as president so why should I stay in a post with nothing to do?

Q. Is Pakistan a failed state?

A. The people of Pakistan have resilience. They understand that, and as long as we have our systems in place and there is a democratically elected government in place along with a strong military, I don't think Pakistan can ever be a failed state.

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**"MANMOHAN AND
I WERE CLOSE TO
SIGNING A PEACE
DEAL IN 2007. ALL
THAT WAS NEEDED
WAS THE BOLDNESS
TO SIGN IT!"**

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